

MIRJ CREATIVE

The AI Playbook

A practical guide for small business owners and enterprise leaders deciding where AI actually fits, and where to start.

Clarity. Alignment. Opportunity.

mirjcreative.com
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INTRODUCTION

About This Playbook

AI is no longer a question of if. For most businesses, it is a question of where to start, how much to commit, and what to trust.

That question gets answered badly more often than it gets answered well. Some businesses wait, assuming clarity will arrive on its own. Others buy tools before they understand the problem those tools are supposed to solve. Both approaches waste money and time, and both are avoidable.

This playbook answers four questions plainly:

- Why AI matters right now, for businesses of every size
- What the benefits actually look like for a small business versus an enterprise
- What has to be true before adoption works
- Where to start, so the investment pays off instead of stalling out

The recommendations in the final section reflect how MIRJ Creative approaches this work with clients directly. Every engagement follows the same method: diagnose the actual friction, clarify what is really happening versus what is assumed, realign the plan to the business's real priorities, then recommend a specific next step. This playbook applies that same method to the broader question of AI adoption.

WHO THIS IS FOR

Small business owners deciding whether AI is worth their limited time and budget, and enterprise leaders trying to turn scattered AI experimentation into something that actually shows up on the P&L. The core questions are the same for both. The starting point is not.

SECTION ONE

Why Use AI?

AI adoption has moved past the experimental phase. Businesses that treated the last few years as a wait-and-see period are now competing against businesses that used that time to build real capability.

88%

of enterprises report regular AI use in at least one business function

80%

of small business owners believe AI will help their business going forward, up from 60% the year before

2x

AI usage among small businesses has more than doubled since 2023

The reason adoption is accelerating is not hype. It is that AI now does something concrete: it removes friction from tasks that used to eat hours every week. Drafting, summarizing, research, scheduling, first pass customer responses, inventory tracking, and reporting are all faster with the right setup. That time comes back to the business, whether it goes toward serving more clients, thinking more strategically, or simply ending the day at a reasonable hour.

The businesses falling behind are not the ones moving slowly on purpose. They are the ones who never made a plan, so nothing ever started.

The cost of waiting

Every quarter spent undecided is a quarter a competitor spends building an advantage that compounds. AI's biggest returns go to whoever has been using it longest, not whoever adopts it fastest at the very end. The businesses winning right now are not necessarily the most sophisticated. They are the ones that picked a starting point and moved.

The Benefits for Small Business

For a small business, AI's biggest advantage is that it closes the gap between what you can do and what you have staff to do.

Half of all workers at small businesses already use AI at work, primarily for personal productivity: drafting, summarizing, and brainstorming, according to the U.S. Chamber of Commerce Foundation's 2026 Main Street AI Monitor. When it works, workers do not just save time, they reinvest it. Fifty nine percent use the time they save to do more work or raise the quality of what they produce. Forty three percent use it to plan, learn, or review work more carefully. That is not replacement. That is leverage.

Time back on repeatable work

Client intake, scheduling, first drafts of proposals and emails, and routine reporting are the tasks AI handles most reliably, freeing up owner and staff time for the work that actually requires a human judgment call.

A more consistent customer experience

Small businesses report using AI most for customer engagement: faster first responses, more consistent follow up, and support that does not depend on one specific person being available that day.

A lower cost of entry than expected

Unlike enterprise AI programs, small business adoption does not require a data team, a large IT budget, or a multi year roadmap. Most of the value comes from applying AI to two or three specific workflows well, not from buying a platform.

A credible way to compete with larger players

When a two person team responds as fast and as consistently as a twenty person team, AI is usually the reason. It is one of the few tools that scales a small business's output without scaling its headcount at the same rate.

The Benefits for Enterprise

For an enterprise, the calculation is different. The number that matters is not just adoption, it is whether adoption reaches the P&L.

According to McKinsey's 2026 State of AI survey, 44 percent of organizations report AI scaling across the enterprise, up from 38 percent the year before, and 37 percent attribute at least some EBIT impact to AI. Only 6 percent qualify as high performers seeing 5 percent or more EBIT impact, which is the real signal: adoption is common, but most organizations are not yet capturing what they are spending on. Meanwhile, 80 percent of employees report improved personal productivity from AI, and 50 percent say it helps them make better decisions. The gap is not whether AI helps people. It is whether the organization is set up to turn that individual benefit into an organizational one.

Measurable operating leverage

The organizations seeing real EBIT impact are the ones treating AI as a business initiative with an owner and a metric, not a scattered set of individual tools.

Faster, more consistent decision making across teams

When half the workforce reports better decisions because of AI, the opportunity is standardizing that benefit rather than leaving it to whichever team adopted a tool first.

Scale advantages larger organizations are built for

Forty percent of large enterprises, over one billion dollars in revenue, now scale AI agents, more than double the 22 percent rate at smaller organizations. Enterprises that already have the infrastructure and governance to support agentic AI are positioned to capture value that smaller competitors cannot yet reach structurally.

Room to build instead of buy

Thirty two percent of organizations report deciding against purchasing new software because they can now build the equivalent internally with AI coding tools, a meaningful shift in how enterprises think about vendor spend.

Where Small Business and Enterprise Needs Diverge

The case for AI is the same at any size. The path to actually getting value from it is not. Before choosing a starting point, it helps to be honest about which column below describes your business.

Dimension	Small Business	Enterprise
Primary constraint	Time and budget	Governance and coordination
Typical entry point	One workflow, tested fast	A structured audit before any rollout
Risk tolerance	Higher, less to formalize	Lower, more to protect
Who needs to be involved	Owner or a small core team	Cross functional leadership, IT, and compliance
Success measure	Hours saved, faster response times	EBIT impact, standardized adoption across functions
Realistic timeline to value	Weeks	One to two quarters

FOR SMALL BUSINESS

You do not need to formalize anything before you start. You need one workflow worth fixing and a clear enough picture of how it works today to know if AI actually helped.

FOR ENTERPRISE

Skipping governance to move fast is how initiatives end up in the 94 percent that never reach real EBIT impact. Slower and structured beats fast and unaccountable.

What You Need to Start

AI adoption fails for a predictable reason: businesses buy tools before they understand the problem. The businesses that get real value from AI, regardless of size, have five things in place before they start.

1 Clarity on the current process, not the ideal one.

You cannot improve a workflow you have not mapped honestly. Before choosing a tool, know exactly how the work happens today, including the workarounds and the steps nobody talks about.

2 A goal tied to a business outcome, not a technology.

"We should use AI" is not a goal. "Cut proposal turnaround from three days to one" is. Every successful AI initiative starts with a specific outcome it is trying to produce.

3 An honest inventory of your tools and data.

AI performs only as well as what it has access to. Knowing what systems you already have, what data is usable, and what is scattered or missing is a prerequisite, not an afterthought.

4 A sponsor who owns the outcome.

Someone needs to be accountable for whether the initiative actually changes how work gets done, not just whether a tool got purchased. In a small business, that is usually the owner. In an enterprise, it needs to be a named leader, not a committee.

5 A pilot scope small enough to prove value fast.

Pick one process. Prove it works. Then expand. The initiatives that stall are almost always the ones that tried to transform everything at once.

Why AI Initiatives Stall

Most AI initiatives do not fail because the technology does not work. They fail for reasons that have nothing to do with the tool.

Starting with a tool instead of a diagnosis

Buying software before understanding the actual bottleneck means solving a problem that may not be the real one.

No one owns the result

When accountability is spread across a team or a committee, initiatives lose momentum the moment something else becomes urgent, which is always.

Success was never defined

Without a specific metric from day one, it is impossible to know if an investment worked, or to justify the next one.

Treating it as an IT project instead of a business one

AI adoption changes how people work. It needs the same change management any operational shift needs, not just a technical rollout.

Trying to fix everything at once

Scope creep kills more AI initiatives than bad technology does. One workflow, proven, beats five workflows, half finished.

THE PATTERN

Every pitfall above traces back to the same root cause: moving to a solution before the actual problem was diagnosed. That is the gap this playbook's final section is built to close.

SECTION SEVEN

Key Entry Points, the MIRJ Creative Way

MIRJ Creative does not start with tools. Every engagement follows the same four step method:

DIAGNOSE

Identify the actual friction, based on evidence from your business, not assumption.

CLARIFY

Separate what is really happening from what everyone assumes is happening.

REALIGN

Match the plan to your business's real priorities, not a generic best practice.

RECOMMEND

Deliver a specific, actionable next step, never generic advice.

That method shows up as four entry points, built so a business can start at the level of commitment that matches where it actually is, and prove value before expanding further.

"Start at the level of commitment that matches where you actually are."

The Entry Point Ladder

Mini Alignment Reset

Starting at \$250

One page diagnostic · 3 to 5 business day turnaround · available once per client

A focused diagnostic on a single process: client intake, project handoff, content approval, or AI automation opportunities specifically. Delivers a one page summary of what is working, what is broken, and three prioritized recommendations. A \$250 deposit is credited toward the total; larger scope work totals \$350.

Best for: Testing MIRJ Creative's approach, or getting clarity on one specific AI opportunity, before committing to anything bigger.

Choose Your Audit: AI Automation Audit

Starting at \$750

Includes a 60 minute debrief call

A full audit identifying where automation can eliminate manual work across the business, not just one process.

Best for: Businesses that want the complete picture of where AI could help before deciding what to prioritize.

Alignment Reset

Starting at \$1,000

2 to 3 week engagement · Discovery, Diagnosis, Realignment · deliverable is a written Alignment Brief

Diagnoses root cause misalignment across people, systems, and priorities. This is not task execution, project management, or virtual assistant support.

Best for: Businesses where the real problem is bigger than any single tool or workflow, and needs to be named before anything gets fixed.

Operations and Automation Retainer

Starting at \$5,000/month

Ongoing engagement · monthly strategy calls and progress summaries

Ongoing process optimization and AI integration, with a partner accountable for progress month over month.

Best for: Businesses ready to move from diagnosis into sustained implementation.

SECTION EIGHT

Which Entry Point Is Right for You

Use whichever line below matches your situation right now. This is meant to be a fast decision, not another thing to deliberate over.

You want to test the waters with minimal commitment

Mini Alignment Reset
from \$250

You want the full picture of where AI could help across your business

AI Automation Audit
from \$750

The problem feels bigger than any one workflow, and roles or priorities are misaligned

Alignment Reset
from \$1,000

You already know what needs to happen and need a partner to build and maintain it

Operations and Automation Retainer
from \$5,000/mo

A NOTE FOR SMALL BUSINESSES

Most small businesses find the Mini Alignment Reset is the right first move, especially when the goal is a single AI opportunity. It is deliberately low commitment, and it is the direct entry point into the Alignment Reset if the diagnostic shows the problem runs deeper.

A NOTE FOR ENTERPRISE LEADERS

Enterprises rarely benefit from starting small on scope. The AI Automation Audit or the Operations and Automation Retainer are built to give leadership the full picture and the ongoing accountability that enterprise scale requires.

What Working With MIRJ Creative Looks Like

MIRJ Creative is not a task execution service. The role is translator and strategist: identifying root causes instead of symptoms, and bringing structure and clarity back to people, systems, and priorities.

Every finding is traceable back to evidence gathered directly from your business, not assumption. Strategic calls are flagged explicitly for your decision, never made unilaterally on your behalf. And the language stays direct: no hedging, no jargon, and no recommendation that is not specific enough to act on immediately.

About MIRJ Creative

MIRJ Creative was founded by Dehjai White, who spent over 15 years in brand events, marketing activations, and creative operations, including roles at Capital One, MAC Cosmetics, and Dillard's. That background now shapes how MIRJ Creative approaches AI: not as a technology exercise, but as a way to bring the same operational discipline that keeps a brand activation on schedule to a business's everyday workflows, faster, more consistent, and easier to scale.

MIRJ Creative works with people centered leaders, founders, and small teams growing faster than their structure has caught up to. The signal is usually role blur, approval bottlenecks, or tool fragmentation, even when nothing looks visibly broken yet.

NEXT STEPS

Start Where You Actually Are

The businesses that get the most out of AI are the ones that started with a clear, specific first step. Not the ones that waited for certainty. Not the ones that tried to do everything at once.

Ready to find your starting point?

The Mini Alignment Reset is built to be that first step: a focused diagnostic on one process, for one flat rate, with a real recommendation you can act on within a week.

mirjcreative.com · hello@mirjcreative.com

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APPENDIX

Sources



McKinsey & Company, "The State of AI: Global Survey," 2026. mckinsey.com

U.S. Chamber of Commerce, "AI, Payments, and Policy: How Technology is Shaping the Future of Small Business," 2026. uschamber.com

U.S. Chamber of Commerce Foundation, "Main Street AI Monitor," June 2026. uschamberfoundation.org

This playbook is provided for general informational purposes and reflects publicly available research as of August 2026. It is not a substitute for a diagnostic specific to your business.